silence them by means of such control. My sense of the cypherpunk ethos was that it could protect people against this: it could turn their knowledge into an unreachable possession of theirs, protecting them in the classic Tom Paine way of securing liberty as a bulwark against harm or aggression. We aimed to turn the tools of oppression into the instruments of liberty and that was a straightforward goal. Eventually, in 1997, this would lead to my developing a new tool called Rubberhose, in which encrypted data can be hidden beneath layers of fake data, such that no single password will ever provide a gateway to a person's sensitive information. The data is essentially unreachable, unless the person to whom the data refers wishes to make an effort to reveal it. It was a way of keeping important information secret not just by encrypting it, but by hiding it, and it was an application of game theory. For the general good, I wished to break the power of interrogators, who could never be sure that the last of the keys had been exhausted. WikiLeaks, I should say, was founded on the notion that the very presence of sources would be infinitely deniable. One day, I imagined, this technology would enable people to speak, even when powerful forces threatened to punish all speakers. The cypherpunks made this possible by arguing, from day one, against all treaties and laws that opposed the right to encrypt.

But I'm getting ahead of myself. Our problems at this time included constitutional issues. At one point, in the early '90s, the US government tried to argue that a floppy disk containing code must be considered a munition. We scarcely knew, as we went about what felt like world-changing business, but on a small scale, that we would be tied up so quickly in freedom-of-speech issues. But we were. Sending certain strips of code or going on a plane with a bit of code tattooed on your arm essentially made you an arms trafficker. Government absurdity has always stalked the effort to make freedoms clear.

I was finding these things out for myself, in Melbourne, in the company of my friends Prime Suspect and Trax. They were the ones who spoke most directly to me in my happy submersion, because they were submerged, too. Prime Suspect said that when he first got his Apple II, at the age of thirteen, he found it to be better company than any of his relatives. Strangely, our bedrooms were more connected to the world than our classrooms, because of one very crucial and amazing thing: the modem. None of us aced our exams or was top of the class. None of us shone in the halls of academe. It